



Blue whale

Balaenoptera musculus

Aside from the tiny, shrimplike krill it eats, everything about the blue whale is supersized. The largest animal on Earth, the blue whale is roughly the size of a jumbo jet. It weighs twice as much as the biggest dinosaurs; even its tongue weighs 4 tons (3.6 metric tons). A human could swim through its blood vessels, which carry 11 tons (10 metric tons) of blood, circulated by a heart that weighs up to 2,000 lb (900 kg)—about the size of a small car.

Despite their huge size, blue whales are almost perfectly hydrodynamic—the long, streamlined body moves through seawater with minimal resistance, propelled by the strong tail. They travel either alone or in small groups, but occasionally up to 60 animals may come together to feed. Blue whales produce the loudest vocalizations on the planet—up to 188 decibels—via a series of low-frequency calls that can be heard underwater for hundreds of miles.

Back from the brink

Their massive proportions kept blue whales safe from human threats until the mid-19th century, when the invention of the exploding harpoon focused the whaling industry's attention on the species. Thousands of blue whales were slaughtered, and despite a 1966 global ban on hunting them, today's population has decreased by an estimated minimum of 70 percent, possibly as much as 90 percent. There have, however, been signs of very slow recovery in recent years, and current blue whale numbers are thought to be around 10,000–25,000.

< HIGHEST SPOUT

At 30–40 ft (9–12 m), blue whales have the highest “blow” or spout of any whale. It happens when the whale expels air through the two blowholes.

- ↔ 105–108 ft (32–33 m)
- 🏠 124–165 tons (113–150 metric tons)
- ⊗ Endangered
- 🐟 Krill, copepods
- 🏠 🌊 🌐



Oceans worldwide, except Arctic

Hourglass dolphin

Lagenorhynchus cruciger



Usually seen far out at sea, hourglass dolphins live in colder, deeper Antarctic and subantarctic waters. They are often found in groups of seven or eight, although schools of 60 to 100 dolphins have also been sighted. They excel at bow-wave riding and frequently approach boats, as well as larger cetaceans such as fin whales, to “catch a ride.” Although little is known about its behavior, research has revealed that this species’ echolocation clicks allow it to find prey at over twice the distance of other dolphins.

▷ PORPOISING

Hourglass dolphins swim at speeds of up to 14 mph (22 km/h), leaping out of the water when riding a bow wave.

- ↔ 5–6 ft (1.5–1.8 m)
- 🏠 Up to 207 lb (94 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Fish, squid, crustaceans
- 🏠 🌊 🌐
- 📍 S. Pacific, S. Atlantic, S. Indian, Southern oceans



Adelie penguin

Pygoscelis adeliae



Adelie penguins nest on large ice-free areas of rock, often far from shore, in colonies up to 280,000 pairs strong. Although new scientific bases and tourism cause disturbance, more than 2 million pairs breed around Antarctica. Their insulation is so good that falling snow does not melt but simply covers them.

- ↔ 18–24 in (46–61 cm)
- 🏠 9–12 lb (4–5.5 kg)
- ⊗ Near threatened
- 🐟 Krill, small fish
- 🏠 🌊 🌐
- 📍 Circumpolar around Antarctica



△ FEEDING IN SHIFTS

Both parents take turns to feed their chick for 16–19 days until it is ready to join a nursery of juveniles.